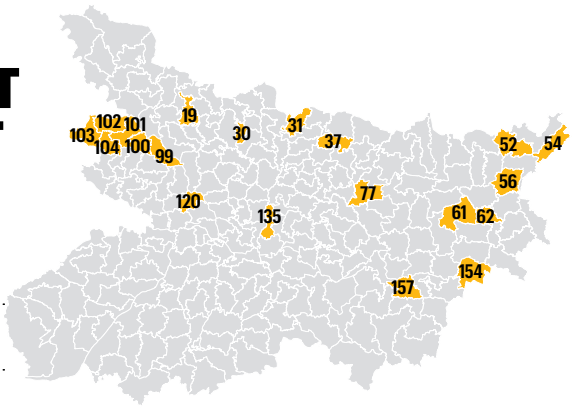
authorities have created '*vanshawalis*' or family trees linking current voters to ancestors listed in the 2003 rolls. These genealogical records, authenticated by panchayats, have enabled approximately 49.6 million voters to establish their eligibility without producing birth certificates or educational documents. This creative solution illustrates the adaptability/absurdity of the entire exercise—the ECI simultaneously insists on documentary proof of citizenship while accepting village-level authentication of family trees.

The Supreme Court, hearing petitions challenging the SIR, has advised the ECI to accept Aadhaar and voter ID cards as valid proof of eligibility. Yet, the commission has steadfastly refused to expand its documentary requirements, maintaining that these commonly held documents do not adequately establish citizenship. The apex court has warned that it will intervene if there is evidence of "mass exclusion", but has not specified what threshold would trigger such intervention. This ambiguity has left millions of voters in a limbo, uncertain whether their names will survive the final cut when the electoral rolls are published on September 30.

SEATS THAT LOST THE MOST

20 constituencies with the highest share of deletions



Constituency *(district)*
% OF DELETED VOTERS

- 101 Gopalganj *(Gopalganj)* 18%
- 102 Kuchaikote *(Gopalganj)* 17%
- 19 Motihari *(East Champaran)* 15%
- 54 Kishanganj *(Kishanganj)* 11.8%
- 100 Barauli *(Gopalganj)* 14%
- 62 Purnia *(Purnia)* 13%
- 104 Hathua *(Gopalganj)* 13%
- 37 Rajnagar (SC) *(Madhubani)* 13%
- 56 Amour *(Purnia)* 13%
- 99 Baikunthpur *(Gopalganj)* 12%
- 30 Belsand *(Sitamarhi)* 12%
- 157 Sultanganj *(Bhagalpur)* 12%
- 120 Amnour *(Saran)* 12%
- 103 Bhorey (SC) *(Gopalganj)* 12%
- 154 Pirpainti (SC) *(Bhagalpur)* 11%
- 61 Dhamdaha *(Purnia)* 11%
- 31 Harlakhi *(Madhubani)* 11%
- 52 Bahadurganj *(Kishanganj)* 11%
- 135 Morwa *(Samastipur)* 10%
- 77 Mahishi *(Saharsa)* 10%

Source: ECI; VoteVibe (comparison based on electoral roll released on Jan. 7, 2025, and draft roll released on Aug. 1, 2025); percentages rounded off

WHILE HIGH DELETIONS IN MUSLIM MAJORITY AREAS NEED EXPLANATION, THEY COULD BE DUE TO FACTORS LIKE MIGRATION ETC. TOO

THE SOUND OF SILENCE

Despite the scale of potential disenfranchisement, the ECI's claim-and-objection process has been met with an almost eerie silence. As of August 7, 5,015 individual complaints had been filed. More remarkably, not a single claim or objection had been submitted by any of the 160,000 booth-level agents deployed by political parties. The Commission has repeatedly emphasised that no name can be deleted from the draft roll without an ERO or assistant ERO conducting an inquiry and providing the affected voter a fair hearing. Orders for deletion must be written down and reasoned out, with provisions for appeal first to the district magistrate and then to the chief electoral officer. But there are huge doubts over whether this elaborate process can handle the potential challenges to millions of names in the limited time-frame, for elections are due in October-November.

Meanwhile, Opposition press conferences, led by the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and the Congress in Bihar, thunder with accusations of "*votebandi*" and deliberate disenfranchisement aimed at helping the ruling NDA, particularly the BJP. They want the ECI to provide comprehensive data on deleted voters so that patterns on how the exercise unfolded across constituencies can be analysed.

The Opposition's predicament was apparent in a moment of political theatre when RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav brandished a voter ID card bearing the number RAB2916120, claiming his name had been struck off the rolls. The ECI's swift rebuttal, confirming that his legitimate card (RAB0456228) remained intact and that the displayed number had never been issued, not only embarrassed the leader of the Opposition in Bihar but also exposed the challenge that political parties are facing: without verified cases of wrongful de-